

Cārvāka — MCQ Questions

32-question closed-book bank · no answer key

Closed-book question bank. Answers and explanations are intentionally omitted.

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MCQ 1

Consider the following statements.

1. *Lokāyata* is standardly explained as the doctrine of the ordinary world or of common people.
2. *Bārhaspatya* names the tradition of Bṛhaspati, whose attributed aphorisms survive as a complete work.
3. The derivations of *Cārvāka* from "to chew" or from "pleasant speech" are doxographical etymologies rather than settled history.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 2 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 3 only

MCQ 2

In classical Sanskrit philosophical classification, *Cārvāka* is called *nāstika* chiefly because it

- A. denies the reality of the perceptible external world along with its material objects and processes
- B. rejects Vedic authority as the primary criterion, while denial of post-mortem existence supplies a secondary sense
- C. denies a creator God, this being the primary test that separates orthodox from unorthodox systems
- D. accepts the authority of the Vedas while rejecting only the ritual apparatus that has grown around them

MCQ 3

Which statement best describes the source position of *Cārvāka* philosophy?

- A. A complete *Bṛhaspati-sūtra* survives, accompanied by commentaries written within the materialist tradition itself.
- B. Nothing responsible can be said about the school, because every surviving witness to it is polemical and hostile.
- C. Mādhava's *Sarvadarśanasamgraha* is an authentic primary work composed by a *Cārvāka* teacher for his own school.
- D. No systematic primary materialist text survives, so reconstruction relies chiefly on convergent reports composed by philosophical opponents.

MCQ 4

In an answer on Cārvāka, the *Tattvopaplavasiṃha* of Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa is best used

- A. as a Nyāya refutation that attacks materialist epistemology from outside the tradition it describes, and therefore as hostile testimony of the ordinary doxographical kind
- B. as the surviving work commonly associated with the tradition and a contested sceptical limit-case that attacks even definitions of perception
- C. as the primary text that positively establishes perception as the sole independent means of valid knowledge, supplying the school with the systematic treatise it otherwise lacks
- D. as a Mīmāṃsā defence of the intrinsic authority of the Veda, written to protect ritual obligation against the epistemological criticisms pressed by the materialists

MCQ 5

The Cārvāka argument for restricting valid knowledge to perception proceeds by showing that

- A. perception is incapable of error, so no further source is needed to correct or supplement its deliverances at any point
- B. inference is acceptable while testimony is not, leaving perception and inference as the only two admissible independent sources of knowledge
- C. every cognition is fundamentally verbal, so perception must be treated as prior to the language in which knowledge is expressed
- D. inference exceeds what is immediately given, while testimony depends on inferred confidence in a speaker and therefore lacks independence

MCQ 6

The statement "Cārvāka denies consciousness" is

- A. incorrect, because the school treats consciousness as an eternal quality inhering in a substance distinct from the living body
- B. correct, because consciousness is not one of the four admitted elements and therefore has no place in the ontology
- C. incorrect, because pleasure, pain and desire are internally perceived while an imperceptible bearer distinct from the living body is denied
- D. correct, because only externally perceived material objects are admitted as belonging to the perceptible world

MCQ 7

The central Cārvāka objection to inference is that invariable concomitance cannot be established because

- A. no inference has ever been observed to succeed, so the practice has no record of reliability to appeal to
- B. universals do not exist, so no relation obtaining between two universals can be stated or known in the first place
- C. finite perception cannot establish universal *vyāpti*, inference would be circular or regressive, and testimony has no independently proved authority
- D. the probans and the probandum are never in fact observed together, so no concomitance is available for generalisation at all

MCQ 8

The *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* argument establishes that

- A. observed constancy may depend on an unnoticed condition and therefore fail to be unconditional
- B. universal relations become secure automatically once a sufficiently large number of positive instances is collected
- C. inference must be rejected because the conclusion drawn from a general rule is invariably found to be false
- D. a decisive counter-instance has already been observed against every universal that has so far been proposed

MCQ 9

Verbal testimony is denied the status of an independent means of valid knowledge because

- A. moving from an utterance to its truth requires inferred confidence in the speaker's competence and honesty, which words cannot certify
- B. words are conventional signs and therefore convey no determinate meaning that could be true or false at all
- C. the Veda is held to be authorless, and an authorless composition can carry no intelligible content for a hearer
- D. language is incapable of guiding practical action, so nothing said can ever be acted upon by a rational agent

MCQ 10

Applying the Cārvāka criterion to comparison (*upamāna*), postulation (*arthāpatti*) and non-cognition (*anupalabdhi*) yields which result?

- A. All three survive as independent sources, because none of them depends on the universal relation that inference presupposes and each rests on a distinct cognitive act.
- B. All three survive as independent sources, because each of them terminates directly in a fresh perceptual presentation of the object whose knowledge is being claimed.
- C. Each either presents only what perception already delivers, adding nothing independent, or moves beyond perception through an unproved universal and inherits the objection to inference.
- D. Only non-cognition survives, because the absence of an object is itself given directly in a single act of perception without any conditional reasoning being required.

MCQ 11

Which set correctly lists the Nyāya devices for establishing invariable concomitance?

- A. Scriptural authority, the intuition of the accomplished yogin, and the reported statement of a person accepted as reliable by the community
- B. An exhaustive enumeration of every past, present and future instance, secured by a survey that no finite observer has yet completed
- C. The postulation of an unseen moral force that guarantees the stability of the regularity across all the cases not yet examined
- D. Agreement in presence and absence, removal of suspected conditions, supportive *tarka*, and later Nyāya perception of universal characters

MCQ 12

The charge of self-refutation against Cārvāka is most precisely stated as follows.

- A. A materialist cannot live consistently, because the necessities of eating, drinking and social life already presuppose a moral order.
- B. The universal denial of inference is not delivered by one perception, so defending that denial appears to require the reasoning rejected.
- C. The rejection of the Veda is inconsistent, because the very Sanskrit in which the rejection is stated is a Vedic inheritance.
- D. The ethics of pleasure contradicts the metaphysics of four elements, because pleasure is not itself an element in that list.

MCQ 13

Which formulation best preserves the refined Cārvāka position on everyday inference?

- A. Everyday inference must be surrendered together with all reasoning about what is absent, since a consistent materialist can appeal to nothing whatever beyond present sensation.
- B. Everyday inference establishes unseen entities whenever it succeeds repeatedly, so accumulated success gradually converts a practical habit into demonstrative and certain knowledge.
- C. Worldly inference is a corrigible expectation answerable to later perception, whereas transcendence-bearing inference lacks any possible perceptual check.
- D. Everyday inference is a genuine means of valid knowledge in worldly matters, while inference employed in scriptural argument alone is disqualified as invalid and unwarranted.

MCQ 14

Arranged by the number of independent means of valid knowledge admitted, which sequence is correct?

- A. Cārvāka one · Nyāya two · Sāṃkhya four · Advaita three, with testimony counted only where scripture is decisive
- B. All classical schools admit exactly three, differing only in the names they give to those three sources
- C. Cārvāka one · Vaiśeṣika and Buddhism two · Sāṃkhya-Yoga three · Nyāya four · Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā five · Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā and Advaita six
- D. Cārvāka two · Nyāya three · Mīmāṃsā four · Advaita five, with comparison counted only inside the Mīmāṃsā tradition

MCQ 15

Which statement about the Cārvāka account of the elements is correct?

- A. Earth, water, fire and air are admitted as perceptible elements, while *ākāśa* is rejected because its alleged substrate-role is inferred.
- B. Three elements are accepted, since air is treated as a rarefied condition of fire and water rather than as an independent element with a sensible quality of its own.
- C. Four elements are accepted and *ākāśa* is retained as a non-substantial medium that accommodates bodies without itself counting as one of the material elements.
- D. Five elements are accepted, including *ākāśa*, because the perception of sound requires an imperceptible substratum in which the quality of sound can inhere.

MCQ 16

Which evidence is characteristically used to identify the self with the living body?

- A. First-person bodily predicates such as being stout or thin, together with the absence of any separately perceived self, support the body-self.
- B. A subtle body is perceived departing at the moment of death, which shows that personhood is exhausted by material organisation.
- C. Scriptural passages are cited in which the self is expressly identified with the gross body rather than with an inner controller.
- D. Memory-continuity is inferred to require a persisting substance, and that substance is then identified with the physical organism.

MCQ 17

The betel and fermentation analogies are offered in order to show that

- A. consciousness is identical with one of the four elements taken singly, most often with the element of fire in the living body
- B. consciousness is an eternal quality of a separate self that the body merely manifests when the sense organs are in working order
- C. the elements are severally conscious already, though their consciousness remains unnoticed until they enter a bodily combination
- D. an organised combination can display a novel property absent from its separate ingredients, so awareness need not require an immaterial bearer

MCQ 18

Sadānanda's *Vedāntasāra* reports four materialist positions distinguished by what each takes the self to be. Which set is correct?

- A. Gross body, subtle body, causal body and the witnessing consciousness that underlies all three of them
- B. The body, the intellect, the store of past actions and the liberated condition attained after their exhaustion
- C. Gross body, the sense faculties, the vital processes, and the internal mental organ
- D. The body, the accumulated moral residue, memory, and the desire that binds a person to future births

MCQ 19

The opponent-preserved formula "death itself is liberation" is best read as

- A. a verse from surviving Cārvāka scripture that formally defines liberation for the materialist school
- B. a positive description of a blissful post-mortem condition attained once the body has been dissolved
- C. a denial of any positive release: bodily dissolution ends the person and therefore ends experienced suffering
- D. a claim that liberation is produced by the correct performance of funerary ritual at the moment of death

MCQ 20

Which statement correctly distinguishes explanation by own-nature (*svabhāvavāda*) from accidentalism (*yadṛcchāvāda*)?

- A. Explanation by own-nature rejects transcendent causation while preserving natural regularity, whereas accidentalism denies determinate causation and is contestably attributed.
- B. Both are orthodox doctrines about an unseen causal order which the materialists rejected in favour of a purely perceptual account of how natural processes come about.
- C. Both deny causation entirely, so the two terms are interchangeable labels for a single Cārvāka doctrine about the natural world and the regularities that are observed in it.
- D. Explanation by own-nature denies all causation, while accidentalism preserves observed regularity by grounding it in chance conjunctions among the four admitted material elements.

MCQ 21

Which statement best expresses the ethical position of the school?

- A. Duty grounded in scripture is retained as a social necessity while liberation alone is rejected as an unverifiable transcendent goal.
- B. Immediate gratification is to be maximised without any weighing of consequence, since consequences lie in a future that cannot be perceived now.
- C. Pleasure and wealth are co-equal ultimate ends of human life, and neither is subordinate to the other in the ordering of goods.
- D. Pleasure is the end and wealth its instrument, while foreseeable pain calls for prudent selection rather than renunciation of embodied enjoyment.

MCQ 22

Which contrast between the two conceptions of reality is accurate?

- A. Cārvāka admits perceptible material particulars, whereas Jainism admits enduring plural substances described through standpoint-conditioned and many-sided predication.
- B. Cārvāka admits plural substances including souls, while Jainism reduces all reality to a single conscious principle that appears as many.
- C. Both restrict reality to matter, differing only over whether the number of material elements is four or five.
- D. Both accept an unchanging reality behind appearances, differing only over whether that reality can be known by perception.

MCQ 23

Which is the strongest reason for qualifying the label "positivistic" when it is applied to Cārvāka?

- A. Cārvāka accepts scriptural testimony in a restricted practical form, whereas positivism excludes revelation altogether from the domain of statements that can count as knowledge.
- B. Positivism depends on scientific inference and law-like explanation, whereas Cārvāka denies inference the status of a means of valid knowledge, so a shared anti-metaphysical spirit conceals opposite methods.
- C. The term is modern and Western, so any comparison between it and a classical Indian school is illegitimate in principle and can only distort both sides of the comparison.
- D. Positivism admits an immaterial self as the subject of experience, whereas Cārvāka identifies the person with the living body and allows no bearer beyond it.

MCQ 24

Which statement correctly differentiates the Cārvāka refusal of a transcendental self from the Buddhist rejection of a self?

- A. Cārvāka denies the self while Buddhism affirms an eternal self that survives the dissolution of the aggregates at death and carries the moral record forward into a further life.
- B. Both denials are identical in content and differ only in the technical vocabulary that each tradition happens to employ when it states its rejection of an enduring self.
- C. Cārvāka denies transcendence but keeps a material bearer, whereas Buddhism denies substantiality, retains causal continuity, and rejects material form as self.
- D. Buddhism identifies the person with the physical body while Cārvāka denies that any bearer of personhood exists at all, whether that bearer is conceived as material or as immaterial.

MCQ 25

Which claim about awareness is actually held by the school?

- A. Awareness is identical with the element of air, which circulates through the body and animates its organs.
- B. Awareness does not occur at all, since nothing beyond the four elements is admitted into the account of the world.
- C. Awareness is an eternal quality inhering in an immaterial self that uses the body as its temporary instrument.
- D. Awareness occurs and is internally perceived, but no imperceptible bearer of it follows from that occurrence.

MCQ 26

A script states: "Because Cārvāka rejects inference, a Cārvāka never reasons from smoke to fire in ordinary life." The error is that

- A. the school in fact accepts inference as a fully independent means of valid knowledge alongside perception
- B. the school denies perception as well, so no example drawn from ordinary observation can illustrate its position
- C. Inference loses independent *pramāṇa* status, not its practical role in moving fallibly from a perceived sign toward what it signifies.
- D. reasoning from smoke to fire counts as testimony rather than inference, so the example is misclassified from the start

MCQ 27

"Fire burns by its own nature" differs from "fire burns because of an unseen moral factor" because

- A. both statements appeal to transcendent causation and differ only in the vocabulary that each of them happens to choose for the cause
- B. The first ends explanation with an observable natural property, while the second adds an imperceptible moral force beyond the perceptual criterion.
- C. the first appeals to divine will while the second appeals to an impersonal physical law that governs combustion wherever it occurs
- D. the first denies that any regularity obtains in nature, whereas the second affirms regularity and offers an account of its stability

MCQ 28

Consider two objections to a proposed universal relation: (i) not every case has been observed; (ii) the observed cases may have shared an unnoticed further condition. Which is the hidden-limiting-condition objection, and why does the difference matter?

- A. Objection (ii), because it survives however extensive the observation becomes, showing that constancy of observation cannot certify unconditionality
- B. Objection (i), because a hidden limiting condition is simply another name for an incomplete survey of the available instances
- C. Both, because the two objections restate a single complaint about the finitude of human observation in different words
- D. Neither, because the hidden limiting condition concerns the formal validity of the syllogism rather than the truth of its premise

MCQ 29

How should the crude and refined (*dhūrta* and *suśikṣita*) contrast be used in an answer?

- A. As another name for the fourfold taxonomy of materialist identifications of the self that Vedāntic sources report and classify
- B. as an opponent-preserved crude/refined contrast whose refined form supplies a possible response to the charge of practical self-refutation
- C. As a modern scholarly invention with no basis in the Indian doxographical literature through which the school has been transmitted
- D. As two securely attested Cārvāka schools with surviving texts, named teachers and datable institutional histories running in parallel

MCQ 30

What survives of the aphorisms attributed to Bṛhaspati?

- A. Nothing whatever, so that not even a single quoted line can be attributed to the tradition with any confidence
- B. No continuous primary text survives, but scattered aphorisms and verses remain in works that usually quote them while mounting refutations.
- C. The complete work, together with at least one commentary composed within the materialist tradition itself
- D. A condensed summary chapter, written by a Cārvāka author for the instruction of students of the school

MCQ 31

How should the verse "as long as one lives, let one live happily", with the associated line about incurring debt, be handled in an answer?

- A. As a word-for-word quotation from the surviving aphorisms of Bṛhaspati, and therefore as decisive documentary evidence
- B. As the school's official ethical formula, sufficient on its own to describe the whole of Cārvāka moral philosophy
- C. as a traditional doxographical verse associated with the school, not as a quotation secured by an extant Cārvāka primary text
- D. As a Mīmāṃsā parody of materialism with no genuine connection to the Lokāyata tradition at any point

MCQ 32

Which use of Jayarāśi in an answer is defensible?

- A. Presenting him as a Naiyāyika author who refuted the materialists from a standpoint outside their tradition
- B. Quoting him to establish that perception alone is the school's single independent means of valid knowledge
- C. Treating him as proof that all Cārvākas denied the existence of the four elements they are otherwise reported to accept
- D. as a contested sceptical wing whose destructive dialectic attacks every positive *pramāṇa* definition without straightforwardly asserting standard materialism